

City Routes

Beijing → Shanghai: The Classic Corridor (4-5 Days)

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The Beijing-Shanghai corridor is China's most iconic high-speed rail journey, connecting the nation's political capital with its financial hub. This 4-5 day itinerary covers the best of both cities plus the thrilling HSR experience that makes Chinese rail travel legendary.

Day 1-2: Beijing -- Imperial Grandeur

Morning: The Forbidden City (故宫)

Start early at the Palace Museum -- the world's largest palace complex with 9,999 rooms.

Book tickets online at least 3 days in advance via the official WeChat mini-program

"故宫博物院" (they sell out fast, especially weekends). Enter through the Meridian Gate

(午门, Wǔmén) and exit via the Gate of Divine Prowess (神武门, Shénwǔmén). Budget 3-4

hours minimum. Don't miss the Clock Gallery (钟表馆) and the Treasure Gallery (珍宝馆)

-- separate ¥10 tickets each.

08:30-17:00 (Apr-Oct) / 08:30-16:30 (Nov-Mar) | ¥60 (Apr-Oct) / ¥40 (Nov-Mar) | ! Closed

Mondays

Afternoon: Temple of Heaven (天坛)

Take Metro Line 5 south to Tiantan Dongmen station. The Hall of Prayer for Good

Harvests (祈年殿) is the iconic triple-gabled circular building you've seen in every China

documentary. The echo wall and circular mound altar are acoustics marvels. The

surrounding park is where locals practice tai chi, play jianzi (毽子), and sing opera -- the

real cultural experience.

06:00-21:00 (park) / 08:00-17:00 (buildings) | ¥15 (park) / ¥34 (through ticket)

Day 2: The Great Wall at Mutianyu (慕田峪长城)



Mutianyu is less crowded than Badaling and more restored than Jinshanling -- perfect for first-timers. Take bus 916 Express from Dongzhimen hub to Huairou, then transfer to bus H23 or take a taxi (¥50-80). Alternatively, book a private car via Didi for ¥200-300 round trip. The cable car (缆车) saves 45 minutes of steep climbing. Walk from Tower 14 to Tower 23 for the most scenic stretch with fewer crowds.

07:30-18:00 (Apr-Oct) / 08:00-17:00 (Nov-Mar) | ¥40 (entry) + ¥120 (cable car round trip)

Evening: Houhai Lake (后海)

Back in Beijing, unwind at Houhai Lake -- a scenic area of hutong alleys, lakeside bars, and live music. Stroll along the lakeshore, grab dinner at a rooftop restaurant, or rent a paddle boat at sunset. The area comes alive after 8 PM with street performers and neon-lit bars reflecting off the water.



Day 3: High-Speed Rail to Shanghai

The Journey: Beijing South → Shanghai Hongqiao

This is the crown jewel of China's HSR network. The G-train covers 1,318 km in just 4

hours 18 minutes at a top speed of 350 km/h. Book via the

12306 app

(铁路12306) -- it's the official railway booking platform, available in English. Book 15

days in advance for guaranteed seats.

Ticket prices (2026):

* Second Class (二等座): ¥553 -- comfortable 3+2 seating, power outlets at every seat

* First Class (一等座): ¥933 -- wider 2+2 seating, more legroom, complimentary snacks

* Business Class (商务座): ¥1,748 -- lie-flat seats, meals included, VIP lounge access

Boarding tips:

Arrive at Beijing South Station (北京南站) 45 minutes early. The station is massive --

follow signs to your gate (检票口). Security is airport-style. Once on board, the dining car

(餐车) is in car 8 or 5 depending on train number. The Wi-Fi works but is slow; download

entertainment beforehand. The countryside views are stunning -- watch the landscape

shift from northern plains to Yangtze delta rice paddies.

Day 4-5: Shanghai -- Future Meets Past

Day 4 Morning: The Bund (外滩)

Arrive at Shanghai Hongqiao Station (上海虹桥站), take Metro Line 2 directly to East

Nanjing Road (南京东路). Walk 5 minutes to the Bund waterfront. The 1.5 km promenade

faces Pudong's jaw-dropping skyline -- Oriental Pearl Tower, Shanghai Tower (632m,

world's 3rd tallest), and the bottle-opener-shaped World Financial Center. Best visited at

sunrise (6 AM, no crowds) or after dark when the skyline is illuminated.

24/7 (outdoor) | Free

Day 4 Afternoon: Yu Garden (豫园) & Old City

Walk south from the Bund (15 min) to Yu Garden -- a 400-year-old classical Chinese garden with rockeries, koi ponds, and pavilions. The surrounding bazaar (豫园商城) is touristy but atmospheric, with traditional tea houses and the famous Nanxiang steamed buns (南翔馒头店) -- expect 30+ minute queues for their xiaolongbao.

09:00-16:45 | ¥40

Day 5 Morning: French Concession & Tianzifang

The Former French Concession (法租界) is Shanghai's most charming neighborhood -- tree-lined streets, Art Deco architecture, independent cafes, and boutiques. Walk along

Wukang Road (武康路) for Instagram-worthy shots of the iconic Flatiron-style Wukang Mansion (武康大楼). Then head to Tianzifang (田子坊) -- a labyrinth of art galleries, craft shops, and tiny bars squeezed into renovated shikumen (石库门) lane houses.

10:00-22:00 (Tianzifang) | Free (entry)

Day 5 Afternoon: Pudong & Lujiazui Skyline

Cross the Huangpu River via the Bund Sightseeing Tunnel (¥55, kitschy but fun) or Metro Line 2. Visit the Shanghai Tower observation deck on the 118th floor -- the world's highest indoor observation deck at 546m. On clear days, you can see the Yangtze estuary. End with dinner at one of Lujiazui's rooftop restaurants overlooking the Bund.

08:30-22:00 | ¥180 (observation deck)

Route Tips

* HSR Booking:

* Use the 12306 app (铁路12306). Register with your passport number. Tickets open 15 days before departure at 8:00 AM Beijing time. Popular routes sell out in minutes -- set an alarm!

* Best Seasons:

* Spring (April-May) and Autumn (September-October). Avoid Golden Week (Oct 1-7) and Chinese New Year -- trains are packed.

* Budget Estimate:

* ¥4,000-6,000 per person for 5 days (mid-range accommodation, HSR tickets, meals, attractions). Budget travelers can do it for ¥2,500.

* Essential Apps:

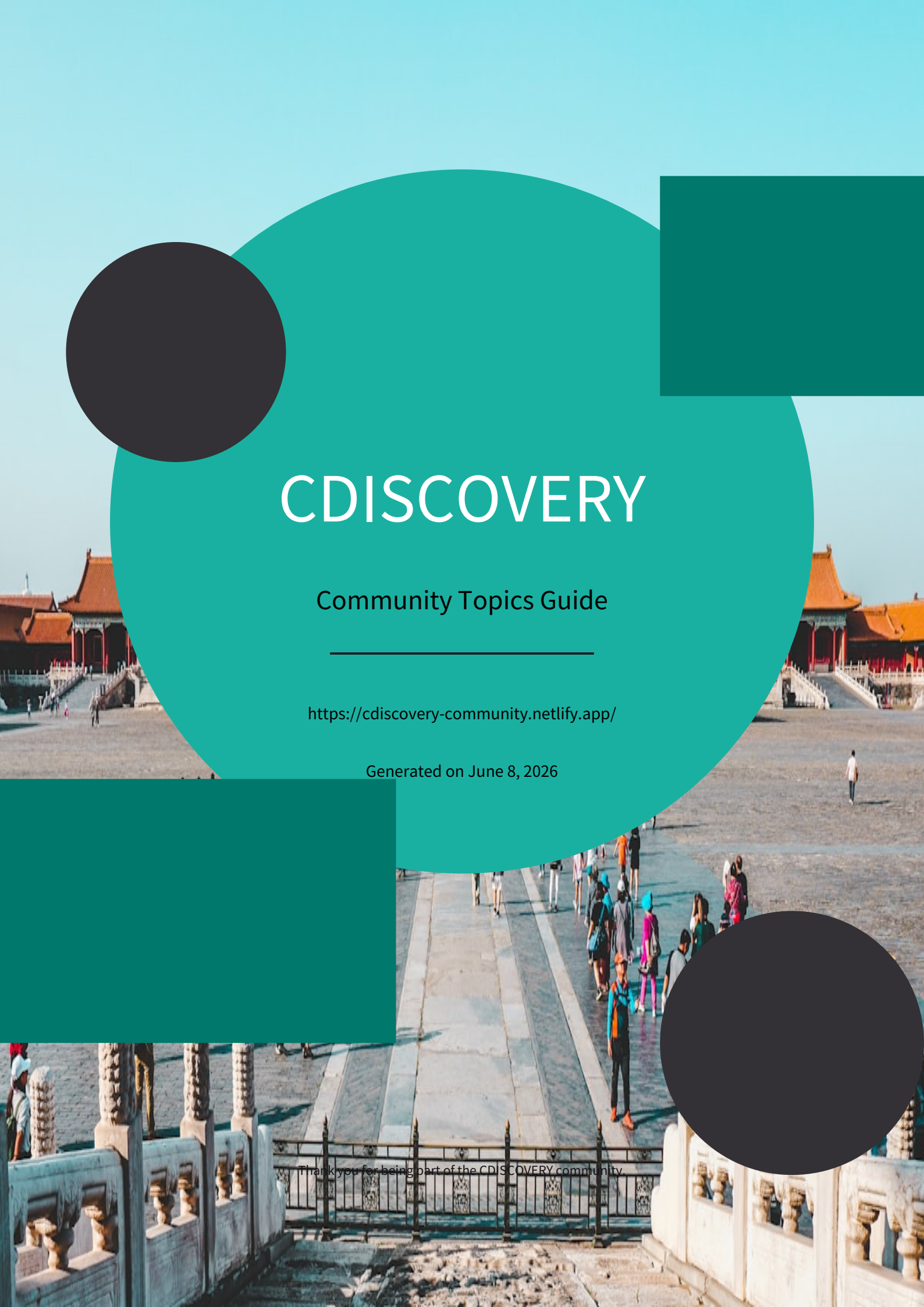
* 12306 (train booking), 高德地图 (navigation), Didi (ride-hailing), 美团 (food delivery & deals), WeChat Pay / Alipay (payments).

* Where to Stay:

* Beijing -- Dongcheng district near Wangfujing or Gulou for hutong vibes. Shanghai --

Jing'an or Huangpu for central location.

Sources: Sources: [12306 Official Railway](https://www.12306.cn) • [The Palace Museum](https://www.dpm.org.cn) • [Shanghai Tower](https://www.shanghaitower.com)



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